



Module 1

You: The Coach

To be a successful running coach you must be versatile, knowledgeable, and dependable. The areas noted in this module represent the different functions that a successful running coach performs. As a coach, involvement in your clients' training and racing can range from relatively basic to extremely complex and involved.

So what exactly do coaches do and what are their responsibilities? To some degree, a coach's role depends on what a client is asking for. However, a coach must be well-rounded, as it is an all-encompassing role.

❖ OBJECTIVES

Upon completion of this module, you should have an understanding of the following areas:

- Roles of a coach
 - Physiologist
 - Psychologist
 - Leader
 - Motivator
 - Disciplinarian
 - Operations manager
 - Instructor and educator
- What constitutes being a professional coach
- How to communicate effectively
- Value of being a comprehensive resource
- Fallacies of being a coach

❖ ROLES OF THE COACH

A running coach must be part exercise physiologist, psychologist, leader, motivator, disciplinarian, operations manager, and, last but not least, an instructor and educator. All of these things are essential to being a successful coach, as your clients will expect you to be a resource in all areas. While you will not serve as a psychologist or exercise physiologist after completing this certification, you will have enough education to develop high-level programs for your clients and also have the knowledge base to identify when to refer them to someone more specialized, if needed.

How clients respond to you will likely vary greatly from one to another. As a coach, you will need to figure out how each client learns best as well as how to motivate each one. For example, some people tend to be more visual than auditory learners. If this is the case and you are discussing running the tangents, drawing a diagram in addition to explaining the concept might prove best. Concerning motivation, you might have clients who respond best to being yelled at (i.e., boot camp), while other clients might feel as though they are being scolded. This is why the way you motivate a client is extremely important. As a successful coach, you will need to discern the best way to motivate each client. It is important to modify your tone, body language, and verbiage to suit each client.

EXERCISE PHYSIOLOGIST

The goal of this certification is to provide you with enough information so you will have a thorough knowledge of basic human anatomy and physiology as it applies to exercise and, more specifically, the sport of running. Having this knowledge base is critical to understanding how to develop and implement programs. While it is not necessary to pass this information along to your client, it is important that you know it. If you were to put this in the context of a visit with your doctor, while the physician most likely communicates with you in layman's terms instead of using medical terminology, you fully expect that the medical professional has the medical training and knowledge to understand and diagnose your illness.

One way to think of the science of exercise is as the foundation of a pyramid. Without this broad knowledge base there can be no application and, therefore, no solid programming for a client. This is not to say that you cannot develop a program without an understanding of anatomy and physiology. However, a

program developed without this knowledge would most likely be based solely on the coach's personal experiences and/or through reviewing other coaching plans. While this method of coaching may or may not develop a successful plan, the bottom line is that you will not have the ability to explain why the program is laid out a certain way or know how to adjust it if it does not work for the client.

PSYCHOLOGIST

It is of paramount importance to listen and relate to your clients. If you are unable to listen to your clients and take what they say into consideration, you will most likely not have much success as a coach. What your clients tell you might not always directly relate to running or training. For example, they might be having difficulties with work, personal relationships, or finances. Your clients may or may not verbally express what else is going on in their life, but, as their coach, it is important to notice changes in their motivation, energy, and attitude. The longer you work with a client the easier it will be for you to identify changes in the person's behavior. Generally, the longer a client works with a coach, the more open the individual becomes about other areas affecting him or her.

While it is not your place as a running coach to advise your clients on matters outside of the sport (i.e., finances, relationships, etc.), you do need to be aware that for some clients, having somebody to speak to about things is an important aspect of the coach/client relationship. It is strongly advised that you do not offer advice on areas outside of running. If your client asks you for your advice in these matters, it is in your best interest to say that it is not your area of expertise and the person would be better served speaking to someone in that subject or industry.

It is not enough only to notice changes in your clients. You also must know how to modify their programs accordingly. For example, if your client is going through a divorce that is demanding a lot of time and energy, you might need to adjust the program to something that is more time and energy efficient while still keeping the ultimate goal in mind.

LEADER

Above everything else, a successful leader is someone who garners respect from those the person leads. A client must be confident that you are the total package. So what is the “total package”?

- Organized and structured
- Educated
- Experienced
- Puts safety first
- Attuned to a client’s psychological needs
- A resource
- Flexible
- Dependable and accountable
- Consistent in the quality delivered
- Honest and trustworthy

Perhaps the most important aspect of being a leader is to understand what you are and what you are not. First and foremost, you are their coach. This is not to say you cannot be friends with your clients. However, this should not be the intent or focus of your relationship. Remember, it is possible to like someone but not respect the person.

MOTIVATOR

In order to get the most out of your client, you will need to be a source of motivation. It is understood that some clients will require more motivation than others, but all will require encouragement to some degree. When taking into account all the other things that a runner must balance with training (i.e., family, job, social life, etc.), it is often difficult to maintain a client’s motivation at the necessary level. The methods used to motivate a client will vary by the individual as not all clients will respond the same way to a particular method of motivation.

It is equally important to know when to back off. This is where the listening component comes into play. For example, if a client experiences a death in the family it is advisable to give the client all the space and time needed prior to resuming training. Other things in people’s lives are far more important than training for running events, and this big-picture approach always is best kept in mind when training clients.

DISCIPLINARIAN

What comes to mind when you hear the word *disciplinarian*? Most likely it is associated with something negative. Pertaining to coaching, discipline should not be viewed as a negative thing, but rather something positive. Being a disciplinarian ties in closely with being a motivator. While it is important to be flexible with clients about their training program, it is equally important to make sure they stay on track to elicit the results they are looking for.

The disciplinarian role of a coach is less a function of being a relentless taskmaster than it is of holding the client accountable. The training program you develop for your client is useful only if the client performs the program the way it was intended. Therefore, your expectations must be clearly stated to your client.

Some clients will need to be held more accountable than others in regard to sticking to their program. However, oversight of all clients' programs is necessary to ensure the proper training progression is accomplished.

OPERATIONS MANAGER

Depending on your level of involvement, you may find yourself thrust into the role of an operations and logistics manager. Some of the aspects of this role might include:

- Travel plans
- Equipment ordering/management
- Event planning
- Contingency planning
- Route scouting

It goes without saying that successful coaching requires strong organizational skills, and the more involved you are as a coach, the more things you will need to juggle. Let's say that you run a successful online coaching business with 50 clients whose goals and training plans vary. First and foremost, you need to remember when you need to contact your clients via either email or phone. Each client should feel as though he or she is your only client instead of one out of 50.

Keeping track of your clients' communication and progress requires organization and structure. While this might not sound like a big deal ... it is. When your client is paying a fee for your services and you promise to email a weekly program on Sunday and follow up with a call each Tuesday at 6 p.m., and you forget to do both, you can assume that you will not have this client for much longer.

It is also your responsibility to have full awareness of the rules of the sport and, more specifically, the rules of any event your clients are participating in. If your clients are participating in track events in the US, most are held under permit of the sport's national governing body (USA Track and Field, or USATF) and as such, USATF rules typically apply.

INSTRUCTOR AND EDUCATOR

As an instructor and educator, it is your job to make sure your clients understand exactly what they are supposed to do and the reasoning behind it. It is your responsibility to convey information to your clients in an effective manner.

Part of an effective message is continuity. This means sending no mixed signals to clients relative to their training program. For example, if you state that Monday is always a rest day no matter what and then a few weeks into the program you have the client do a hard workout on Monday, this sends a mixed message and over time will erode trust and confidence between you and your client.

Not all clients will want instruction the same way; however, some basic principles should underlie how you instruct your clients. Some of these are:

- Encourage your client
- Provide explanations on your program design
- Be as clear and concise as possible
- Provide feedback and honest assessments
- Perform goal-setting exercises
- Be positive
- Be realistic in your expectations of the client
- Continuity

It is helpful to teach your clients the rationale behind their program. While some clients will want to know more than others, it is important they understand the

basic reasoning underlying the program. The more you educate your clients, the better they will understand the reasoning behind their program and become active participants in its design and development, leading to a more effective program.

An analogy would be the relationship between a race car driver and pit crew. Unless the driver has a good understanding of how the car handles based on its inner workings, the driver will not be able to communicate effectively with the pit crew on how to adjust the car to make it faster. Communicating your training strategy to your client is critical to ensuring that both you and client are on the same page.

The coach/client relationship is a two-way street. The client is learning from you and you are continually learning from the client.

PROFESSIONAL

It is important to convey to your client what you know and what you do not know. The guiding principle at all times should be your clients' best interests. For example, just because you have an idea about why a client's knee is hurting, unless you are a doctor or physical therapist (or similar specialist), you are not qualified to diagnose this and the correct decision is always to refer the person to a specialist. Likewise, if your clients ask you something you do not know, it is correct to tell them that you will get back to them with the answer or refer them to someone who will have the answer. By trying to be everything to your client, you are actually doing a disservice to them, and in some cases, your actions could be illegal and potentially injurious.

Honesty

A key component to professionalism is honesty. While this seems like a simple statement, it often is the most difficult rule to follow. As an example, you start coaching a client who is very fit and strong, and despite having results that are in the middle of the pack, the runner's goal is to win the individual's age group at a very competitive race. While goals are necessary and stretch goals are a good idea, a client's goal must be within the realm of possibility. Therefore, in this particular situation, it is your professional responsibility to inform the client that the person's expectations are most likely too high given their current level of

conditioning and the competition at the event. This is not always an easy conversation, but in order to progress the client properly, it is a necessary one. This is an example of how to treat a client honestly, with integrity, and with respect. There are ways to make this conversation as painless as possible, but at the end of the day, it is of crucial importance that you clearly convey an accurate message to the client.

Part of being honest also involves knowing when to say you do not know something. Oftentimes coaches feel as though they must know everything because they have been hired by a client and therefore must be an all-knowing resource. First, you will never know everything there is to know about the sport of running. Second, and as noted previously, it is okay to say, “I don’t know,” to your client. It is much better to say, “I’m not sure, let me get back to you,” than it is to guess, lie, or bluff your way through an answer. Not only is this disingenuous, but it could lead clients off track with their training or, worse, to injury.

Verbal and Physical Actions

Being professional also relates to your verbal and physical actions. If you are working with a client one-on-one, you should aim to arrive at the meeting location five minutes ahead of the designated time. During your session, your client is the *only* person that matters and must have 100 percent of your focus. For example, if your session takes place at a personal training studio, you should not be watching TV, checking your email (turn your phone off or to vibrate), talking to other staff or members, or in any way taking the focus off your client. To that same end, your body language and attire says a lot about you as a professional – especially with new clients who do not know you well. During your session, you should always stand or kneel if you need to watch their form from a lower level. You should never sit, lie down, or lean against a wall. When this occurs, the perception from a client’s point of view is often that of laziness and a lack of professionalism. In regard to attire, dress should not be sloppy nor should it have potentially offensive verbiage or images.

Lastly, the verbiage that you use with your client reflects on you. If you swear, tell off-color jokes, and use poor grammar or slang, this paints a picture of someone who is unprofessional and does not take the occupation seriously.

Stay Current

A professional in any field must remain current on all the latest developments. This is the only way to stay relevant. For a coach, this means staying up-to-date on training and coaching methodologies as well as equipment. The credibility of a coach is not limited only to areas that involve the actual training process, but also the sport as a whole.

EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATOR

This is perhaps the single most important aspect of developing an effective training program. Without effective communication between you and the client, it is almost certain that the resulting program will be ineffective. As noted previously, communication between you and your client is a two-way street. Initially, clients need to communicate what their goals are, their health and athletic background, what their bandwidth is in regard to training capacity, as well as perceived strengths and weaknesses. Once training begins, clients need to communicate their feelings and perceptions of the program's effectiveness. You need to communicate your coaching philosophy along with your expectations. Throughout the training process, you need to listen to the client's feedback and communicate effectively in return regarding modifications to the training program and the reasons behind them.

Generally speaking, most coaching program failures are the result of poor communication. To a large degree, the effectiveness of communication is based on honesty. If a client was supposed to run 10 miles but only did two and reports doing 10, this will become an issue because you will progress the client based on 10 miles. This may result in overtraining, injury, or both. If a client has never participated in a running race but signed up for a marathon taking place in two months and wants you to help in preparation for it, it is your responsibility to advise this is not possible and the person should revise the goal. As a coach, you need to learn how to manage your clients' expectations, and sometimes this means having hard conversations about what is or is not possible.

Typically, losing a client is considered a bad thing although sometimes it is for the best. Like all relationships, there will be difficulties and sometimes relationships do not work out. This is not good or bad, but simply a reality. Relationships between coaches and clients do not work out for various reasons. Some of the more common ones are:

- Personality conflicts
- Coaching philosophy disagreements
- Lack of perceived results on the part of the client
- Inflexibility of time by either party
- Lack of professionalism by either party

While it is the hope that some or all of these issues could be mitigated early in the relationship through proper and honest communication, it is a reality of coaching that not all clients will work out for one reason or another. A professional coach does not take these things personally and knows when to recommend terminating a coaching relationship with a client.

Professionalism needs to be evident in all areas of the coaching/client relationship. Below are some of the areas:

- Email
- Phone
- Timeliness
- Sensitivity
- Boundaries

Email

Your emails should be proper and professional. What does this mean? It means no emoticons, slang, texting-style abbreviations, spelling errors, all CAPS, unnecessary exclamation points, or improperly constructed sentences.

In short, your emails should be constructed in the same manner as a thank-you letter for an interview. They should be to the point and with a clear and concise message. While this sounds trivial, the ability to compose a professional email is of utmost importance. It tells the client that you are professional and you care. Be sure to reread all emails prior to sending them.

It is strongly advised to use a different email account for your coaching business. Make sure that your email address is also professional.

Phone

Do not use slang words, and speak clearly and professionally at all times. Both email and phone are similar in that you do not have the advantage of seeing the facial expressions or body language of the other person. Therefore, your words and tone can easily be misconstrued. Because of this, you want to ensure that you are presenting yourself professionally at all times to minimize the chance of being misinterpreted.

Timeliness

As noted previously, if you tell a client you will call or send an email at a particular time, you must do so. If you agree to meet your client at a designated location and at a set time, you should arrive at least five minutes before the set time. It is immaterial whether your client gets there late or not. Your clients are paying you to provide them with a service and deserve a coach who respects their time.

Assuming your client's training session has a predetermined duration, it is your responsibility to structure the session to accomplish what you need to within the established time. Your client might not be wearing a watch and might need to leave right at the session's end. Also, if you exceed the time limit you risk cutting into your next client's appointment time. It is your responsibility to run the session effectively and pay attention to the session duration.

Sensitivity

It is important to be sensitive to your client's emotions and current issues. Many of these areas you will learn about only during the training process. For example, perhaps you have clients who are very sensitive about their weight. If this is the case, you will need to devise a communication strategy regarding how to communicate effectively with them while not offending them.

As noted previously, you should avoid discussing areas of their personal life such as finances, religion, human rights, politics, and any topic of a sexual nature. You are hired to be a running coach – no more, no less. Of course, you will venture into areas of small talk with your client, but try to keep the conversation light. If your client asks for your opinion on any of the aforementioned issues, respond by saying that you would rather not discuss it.

Boundaries

This is an important issue for all coaches. Many coaches become “friends” with their clients, especially if they have worked with them for a long time. To some degree, this is normal and acceptable. It is what you do with your client that determines what is acceptable or not.

Some things not to do are:

- Meet for activities other than coaching or running-related events
- Emails and phone calls about anything other than coaching
- Discussing your personal lives beyond what may be perceived as comfortable (e.g., talking about your client’s kids’ soccer game is okay, but talking about your client’s messy divorce is not okay)
- Date your client
- Assume that based on the length of your coaching relationship you are free to ask your clients questions about their personal life

If you move outside professional boundaries, you are diminishing your professional relationship and will risk losing clients altogether. In summation, it is your responsibility as a professional coach to use sound judgment regarding what is acceptable to discuss or do with your clients.

❖ FALLACIES

YOU MUST BE FAST!

It is not uncommon for running coaches to promote their business by using their personal records or number of races run. While personal running experience is helpful to the coaching process, the ability to run “fast” or have a set number of races under one’s belt is not a prerequisite to being a quality coach. Conversely, one could make the argument that being a talented and fast runner may result in coaches being less effective, as they cannot relate to slower runners. The bottom line is that there is no correlation between being a fast runner and being a great coach. It is much more important for a coach to be inquisitive, constantly learning, and humble. Also note that what constitutes “being fast” is very much subjective.

This does not mean that potential clients won't be impressed by fast personal records and seek out like coaches. Therefore it is important to understand that if this topic comes up when speaking to prospective clients, you need to educate them on what constitutes real value when hiring a running coach.

Many “fast” coaches rely on their personal race résumé as a marketing tool and also derive their coaching practices based on their own training. This is misguided and akin to a research study with one participant. While one could argue that this is evidence-based, it is hardly statistically significant! Remember, a training methodology that works great for one person may not work great for another. This is the genesis of this certification – put your trust in science and statistically significant evidence-based findings and you will become a professional and effective coach.

HOLDING BACK

A theory among some sports and fitness professionals holds that if they give clients too much information, they will fire them as they now have the knowledge to coach themselves. Let's first address this issue by remembering why you want to become a coach. As a professional running coach, it is your responsibility to act in the best interest of your clients to help them reach their goals. This typically involves explaining the training process and the science behind it – at least in an abbreviated fashion – when applicable and warranted. To hold back training information from clients for fear that they will leave you is unprofessional at best and unethical at worst. If this is your desired future coaching direction, stop reading right now and contact UESCA and we will refund your money, as this is not the type of coach we want to be affiliated with.

It speaks volumes of your overall coaching practice if you feel that acquiring information in the short term is the only reason why a client is hiring you. As noted previously in this module, the role of a professional running coach is multifaceted. You are there to provide moral support, tweak a program based on near limitless variables, devise a realistic and manageable race strategy and, when needed, recommend and/or help facilitate third-party interventions such as physical therapists and physicians.

Your ability and willingness to explain the science behind your training programs should serve to legitimize you and your coaching practice and increase the value of your services, not the other way around.